

Illustration by NILANJAN DAS/AI

> **"The real estate of the front of the pack is important. Nobody's looking at the back and the fine print"**
>
> **— ROHIT K. SINGH,** *Ex-Secretary, Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution*



nutrients were at first proposed to be covered in the first phase, with those exceeding the threshold for just one coming under a subsequent phase. But no deadline was specified for Phase II. Hyderabad-based paediatrician Dr Sivaranjani Santosh, a spokesperson for 3S and Our Health Society, fears such a second stage could be postponed indefinitely. The SC, too, in its September 10 hearing asked why the FSSAI was leaning towards a more lenient rollout with two phases, imposing only a two-nutrient threshold to trigger a red hexagon warning in the first. In response, the FSSAI said it will adopt stricter FOPL norms than it has proposed and is also willing to forgo the two-phase implementation.

There are other distinctions with major consequences: added versus total sugar and fat. According to Santosh, the ICMR-NIN (National Institute of Nutrition) Dietary Guidelines for Indians 2024 prescribe thresholds for total sugar and total fat per 100 grams. The FSSAI's proposal, by contrast, focuses on added sugar and added saturated fat. A juice naturally high in sugar could therefore escape a warning as long as no sugar was added during manufacturing.

A LocalCircles survey of 20,525 respondents across 328 Indian districts in September 2026 found that 53 per cent wanted warnings to be based on the total amount of sugar, salt and saturated fat rather than just the added quantity.

Even typography has become a matter of contention. The FSSAI proposed making the warning lettering just a point larger than the nutritional information on the back, which is typically printed in six-to-eight-point type. Gupta argues this defeats the objective. "The bigger font is not only more readable but also suggests to the reader what is important to be read first." Campaigners point out that Mexico and several other countries use warnings deliberately designed to catch the eye. Also, in a country as linguistically diverse as India, there is another question: what language should the warnings use? Campaigners advocate labels at least in Hindi and English, comparable to Canada's bilingual English-French system.

WHY THE FOOD INDUSTRY IS WORRIED

India's packaged food industry has genuine concerns about what a red warning symbol implies. In a recent interview with BUSINESS TODAY TV, Rajit Punhani, CEO of the FSSAI, acknowledged that there is pressure from industry on regulating packaging and labels, though he said that pressure was easy to resist because they had consumer support. However, he added that forming new regulations takes time as consumer awareness is a recent phenomenon and the FSSAI itself is a relatively young body, just 18 years old.

As for industry stakeholders, they are objecting not to providing nutritional information, but to reducing a complex nutritional profile to merely sugar, salt and saturated fat. A product with relatively high levels of one of these may also provide protein, fibre or other nutrients. Anil Rajput, chair of the food